In the meantime, both sides met in Herzog's residence and agreed on various technical matters relating to the substantive discussions that will start immediately after Passover. The atmosphere is apparently positive.

Netanyahu held a press conference. Three main points: Gallant remains as defense minister; the previous government was responsible for the worsening security situation; Ben-Gvir's national guard will not be under his command, but under the command of one of the existing security forces (the army or the police). Netanyahu was asked about yesterday's poll and brushed it off. Regarding the security situation, he promised that his government would repair all the damage caused by its predecessor. In fact, these were all merely general statements, except regarding Gallant. Netanyahu understood that dismissing Gallant would bring his coalition down.

The leaders of the opposition derided Netanyahu's declarations. Gantz: "whining." Lapid: "loss of control." Bennett: "no leadership." In Tel Aviv, thousands demonstrated against the PM, as they grasped that the government has tried to shift all responsibility for the current difficulties onto the opposition and the protest movement. What poor leadership!

In his rebuttal, Bennett proved that Netanyahu lied brazenly in his description of the security situation under his predecessor. Netanyahu is an inveterate liar, but now it works less and less. He should give it up, but he won't because of the indictments hanging over him.

The settlers, with Smotrich and Ben-Gvir at their head, are a real danger. Israel started on this path in the far-away past, but even if a leader like Begin was a true believer in the whole of Eretz Israel ideology, he remained a weird kind of liberal. In 1983, I received the Israel Prize for History from his religious education minister, Zevulun Hammer, although my opinions in favor of the two-state solution were well known. On the morning of the prize distribution, I joined a group of protesters against a new settlement at Har Bracha, in the West Bank; that did not stop Hammer from handing me